dak 2), Vasan Bala (*Peddlers*) and Reema Maya (*Nocturnal Burger*) to direct for Dharma.

The Hindi film industry had its all-time best year theatrically last year, with domestic revenues reaching Rs 12,000 crore and three films—*Pathaan*, *Gadar 2* and *Jawan*—breaking into the new club of Rs 500 crore. Indian cinema, long seen as too diverse, is now a more unified entity thanks to OTT platforms that carry content with subtitles and film channels that carry dubbed films. The result being that actors like Prabhas (*Baahubali* and *Kalki 2898 AD*), Allu Arjun (*Pushpa*), Yash (*KGF films*), Fahadh Faasil (*Aavesham*) and Vijay Sethupati (*Maharaja*) are widening their fan base beyond their respective states. Films are now being enjoyed without barriers. Collaborations are gaining traction—Shah Rukh Khan entrusted Tamil filmmaker Atlee to make a Hindi film (*Jawan*) and Nag Ashwin roped in the stalwart Amitabh Bachchan and Deepika Padukone to play key roles in his sci-fi epic *Kalki 2898 AD*.

Over the years, many Indian films have captivated hearts and minds the world over and shaped pop cultural sensibilities. The next step is making a sizeable dent in the global box office, as Aamir Khan's *Dangal* did in China in 2016.

FROM ENTHRALLING THE AUDIENCE AT GLOBAL MUSIC FESTIVALS TO ARTISTS HAVING THEIR WORKS SHOWCASED AT MUSEUMS LIKE MOMA, INDIA IS BECOMING MORE PROFICIENT IN THE ART OF SHOWCASING ITS RICH AND VARIED CULTURE



THE QUEST FOR MEDALS

India's Olympics campaign in Paris may not have gone as per plan, yet despite the many heartbreaks, the contingent returned with six medals, just one short of its haul in Tokyo three years back. Even as cricket continues to be the invincible big daddy of sports, efforts are being made to show that India isn't a one-trick pony. Earlier this year, Prime Minister Narendra Modi shared his desire of India hosting the 2036 Olympics. Economic prowess and infrastructure though won't help India's bid, for what will matter is also the talent and size of its contingent. For 2036 to become a reality, the groundwork to boost India's participation in other disciplines needs to get going now.

The government, on its part, has increased the sports budget for its flagship project Khelo India, which promotes athletes from the grassroots level with a series of competitions, to Rs 900 crore. The Sports Authority of India, which apart from its centres also manages the Centre's TOPS (Target Olympic Podium Scheme to assist sportspersons participating in international competitions and training abroad) initiative, was allocated Rs 822.6 crore. But there's scope for more. "The place where we are missing out is participation of private sectors in funding from their CSR budgets," says Bhavit Sheth, co-founder and COO of Dream Sports, a sports tech conglomerate which supports athletes like India's top table tennis player Sreeja Akula, among a host of others. Some progress has been made. While the army and navy and PSUs like Bharat Petroleum and Indian Oil Corporation have had a long tradition of providing job security and financial support to athletes, corporate influence in sports has increased with Reliance Foundation, JSW Sports and the Tata Group investing in athletes as well as developing facilities.

However, for India to be a sporting powerhouse in the league of United States, China and Japan—countries that finished in the top three in the medal table of the 2024 Olympics—the role of sports science is as significant as coaching, mental conditioning and nutrition, says Sheth. He also identifies the lack of competition, at school, university and international levels, as a factor that has hindered the growth of talent. "Until we develop an ecosystem in other sports like we have for cricket and international exposure like IPL provides, sports can't grow," says Rajkumar Dubey of Bharat Petroleum, the PSU that has 56 sportspersons currently on its payroll across 15 different disciplines and another 28 under contract and scholarship.

LIBERATING THE ARTS

On March 31, 2023, India flexed its cultural muscles with the launch of the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre (NMACC) in Mumbai, for which the who's who gathered to watch the musical *Civilization to Nation* at the opulent Grand Theatre, the only venue in the country that has the tech and logistic specifications to host big-scale Broadway shows. But as much as NMACC has provided a much-needed fillip to the rich performing arts traditions and artists with the gallery space and pavilions, there's a need for more such institutions that make art accessible and also appealing.

"What the government sometimes tries to do is use insti-